

Sadaf Kazmi
Dick Benka
Jeff Rudolph
Mariah Nobrega, SC
Cliff Brown, AC



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Expenditures & Revenues Study Committee Agenda
E&RSC Schools Subcommittee
Monday, March 2, 2026 at 5:00 PM

- 1. Call to Order**
- 2. Miscellaneous**
 - 2a. Question of approving the minutes from February 17, 2026.
 - 2b. Question of approving the minutes from February 23, 2026.
- 3. Discussion on School financials, proposed override numbers, and non-override scenarios**
- 4. Workstream Updates**
 - 4a. BEEP analysis review & vote - Jeff
 - 4b. CLA report update review & vote - Sadaf
 - 4c. Temperatures in schools - Mariah
 - 4d. Teaching loads discussion & possible recommendation
 - 4e. Updated enrollment forecast recommendation & vote
- 5. Subcommittee report draft review & discussion**
 - 5a. School Subcommittee Executive Summary and Introduction Sections DRAFT 03.01.2026 v2
 - 5b. Capacity To Pay
- 6. New Business**

[Expenditures & Revenues Study Committee Webpage](#)

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School Subcommittee of Expenditure & Revenue Study Committee

Minutes for February 17, 2026

1. Call to Order and Roll Call: The meeting was called to order by Acting Chair Jeff Rudolph.

Voting Members Present: Jeff Rudolph (Acting Chair), Dick Benka, Cliff Brown, Mariah Nobrega

Non-voting participants and members of the public: Advisory Committee member Carol Levin, Town Administrator Charles Carey, School Committee Chair Val Frias, School Committee member Carolyn Thall, Assistant Administrator Nicole Lima and other staff and participants as noted during discussion

2. Approval of Prior Meeting Minutes (February 2): The Committee reviewed the minutes of the February 2 meeting.

Motion: To approve the February 2 meeting minutes.

Moved by: Jeff Rudolph

Seconded by: Mariah Nobrega

Votes in favor: Jeff Rudolph, Dick Benka, Cliff Brown

Votes Opposed: None

Abstentions: Mariah Nobrega

Result: Motion carried 3-0-1.

3. Building Management Discussion and Recommendations: The Committee continued its discussion regarding building management practices, responsibilities, and potential policy recommendations. Carol Levin presented background analysis and observations regarding current municipal building operations.

Key Discussion Points

A. Need for Written Occupancy and Service Agreements: Ms. Levin emphasized the absence of clearly documented policies defining operational and financial responsibilities for town facilities. She recommended the development of standardized **occupancy and service agreements** applicable across all departments.

Key objectives would include:

- Clarifying operational responsibilities
- Defining financial accountability

- Establishing consistent management practices
- Protecting long-term municipal assets

Members discussed that town facilities represent significant taxpayer investment and that accountability structures should reflect the Town's ultimate financial liability.

B. Above-the-Line vs. Below-the-Line Budget Treatment: The Committee discussed alternative budgeting structures for public building operations.

Advantages discussed for below-the-line treatment:

- Encourages departmental accountability
- Creates incentives for efficient resource use
- Makes operating costs more visible

Advantages discussed for above-the-line treatment:

- Simplifies governance and control
- Reduces jurisdictional disputes
- Centralizes authority

Members acknowledged trade-offs between administrative clarity and behavioral incentives. No formal recommendation was adopted; however, consensus emerged that further analysis is required.

C. Long-Term Facility Cost Awareness: Discussion highlighted that:

- Newer buildings often increase maintenance complexity and cost.
- Communities frequently expand facility footprints without evaluating long-term operating affordability.
- Annual operating costs—including utilities, maintenance, insurance, and staffing—are not consistently analyzed alongside space decisions.

Members agreed that improved cost transparency would support better long-term planning.

D. Rental Policies and Revenue Opportunities: The Committee discussed facility rental practices and potential unrealized revenue opportunities, including:

- Lack of accurate cost data for building usage
- Uncertainty regarding true operating costs of rented spaces
- Possible under-charging for facility usage
- Instances where nonprofit organizations occupy municipal space without clear compensation structures

Members emphasized the importance of consistent policies across departments and facilities and regarding all third-party building users.

E. Data Needs: The Committee identified a need for:

- Accurate cost accounting for facility operations
- Better understanding of HVAC and operational impacts of space usage
- Standardized evaluation of rental pricing

Members agreed that reliable data is necessary before policy changes can be recommended.

F. Potential Recommendations Under Consideration: Ideas discussed for future inclusion in the Committee's report included:

- Creation of written occupancy and service agreements
- Establishment of a working group to develop implementation details
- Integration of building management concepts into broader facilities or rental policy recommendations
- Development of consistent town-wide building management standards

4. Budget and Forecast Discussion: The Committee briefly reviewed ongoing budget considerations, including:

- Preliminary three-year financial projections
- Anticipated school and town budget updates
- Timing considerations for override discussions
- Pending external policy decisions affecting financial forecasts

Members agreed that substantive discussion should occur after receiving additional presentations and updated financial information.

5. New Business: A non-committee participant raised concerns regarding potential revenue opportunities related to nonprofit use of public-school buildings. The Committee agreed that the issue aligns with broader facility management discussions and may be incorporated into future recommendations.

6. Next Steps

- Updated memorandum on building management to be revised and circulated prior to the next meeting.
- Committee to revisit recommendations following additional financial presentations.
- Continued coordination with full committee schedule.

7. Adjournment: With no further business, the meeting adjourned by consensus.

E&RSC Schools Subcommittee Meeting Minutes – 2/23/26

Sadaf agreed to take minutes for the meeting.

Roll Call

All of the committee was present during the meeting: Cliff Brown, Dick Benka, Mariah Nobrega, Sadaf Kazmi, and Jeff Rudolph.

Minutes: Minutes from 2/9/26 were reviewed and approved by a vote of 4-0-0. Mariah arrived late to the meeting so did not vote.

BEEP Analysis

The group discussed the BEEP program, with Jeff presenting an updated document that included new background information and waiting list process, projected tuition and cost increases, and information on most popular locations which are the FRR and Driscoll locations. Jeff shared that he had spoken with Margaret Eberhardt (BEEP principal), who agreed to send him additional information that will enable him to validate his financial analysis. Sadaf suggested adding language about the waiting list indicating additional demand for the program and moving the recommendation regarding extended day to the top of the document. Cliff requested more information on the number of applicants and suggested that the information on the revolving fund be broken out to increase transparency. Jeff agreed to update the document with this recommendation and to follow up with Margaret again, with a goal of reviewing the updated document at the 3/2/26 meeting.

Facilities Usage Updates

Cliff and Carol explained that they had integrated Carol's memo into the facilities rental document, with the memo now serving as an appendix that applies to all town assets rather than just schools. Mariah agreed that there is currently likely money left on the table, but added that if we fully account for the cost of the facilities space that the space may be so expensive that it is cost prohibitive to rent. However, that would be important to know as well.

Mariah raised questions about the Recreation department's usage of facilities and what they pay to cover given they are generating revenue. Cliff clarified that the Recreation department pays the town for to cover operating costs. Mariah suggested that Recreation's reimbursement model through its revolving fund should be considered in any comprehensive facilities usage agreement, particularly regarding utilities costs which are currently being absorbed by the PSB operating budget.

Carol emphasized the need for a standardized template for occupancy agreements to ensure consistency across town departments, advocating for a holistic approach rather than department-specific negotiations. She highlighted the importance of aligning incentives with cost responsibilities, ensuring that entities in control of buildings bear the associated expenses, such as utility charges for special equipment. Dick and Sadaf supported Carol's view on incentivizing cost savings and maintaining visibility of operational expenses. Sadaf favored Option B for its

alignment with incentives and cost visibility. Carol acknowledged needed further consideration of both options to work through the details. Cliff raised a question about whether below-the-line allocations could be redirected by the school committee and Charles Carey said yes. The group spoke about reducing building temperatures and how the cost savings would be accounted for. Carol Levin warned against relying on temporary utility savings to reduce future budgets, noting that usage is dependent on environmental conditions and could expose the district to increased costs. Mariah proposed moving building repair and maintenance funds above the line to ensure adequate funding.

The group discussed the allocation of costs and benefits between the town and schools, with Carol and Chas highlighting how above-the-line costs can create misunderstandings about funding for both entities. They explored the pros and cons of keeping costs below the line, with Chas favoring this approach for clearer budget responsibility and accountability. Dick raised concerns about the legal structure and financial implications of benefit allocation, while Mariah clarified that staff are aware of the implications of their decisions on staffing and benefits. Cliff emphasized the need for better presentation of budget information to address misconceptions about school funding. They debated how to present this information to the public, with Cliff expressing concern that the message might be misleading.

They also discussed the need for strong organizational structures and controls to prevent potential budget issues, with Charles emphasizing the importance of systems over relying on individual good behavior and saying that while it is possible that people may misuse additional funding that would be allocated “below the line” it’s not plausible that that would happen.

The group agreed to move the buildings appendix and rental document to the financial model discussion, as suggested by Sadaf, and agreed to revert the recreation rentals document back to its prior version.

Town-School Financial Model Discussion

The group discussed the need to reassess which budget items should be above or below the line, with a focus on creating appropriate incentives for cost management. Mariah shared that while the above the line/below the line designations should be evaluated, the document should reflect more nuance than to simply say (as it does currently) that more expenses should be moved below the line because some expenses could be moved above the line as well. Sadaf acknowledged the need to update the document to reflect these discussions and agreed to reframe the recommendations accordingly.

The group discussed and approved edits to a document about town-school partnerships, including clarifying language around departmental consolidation and building maintenance. They agreed to evaluate full consolidation of services based on expertise rather than assuming they should go to the town side. The subcommittee voted 4-0-1 to approve the Town/School Financial Model document with the edits that were discussed. Sadaf will update the document

and circulate it by tomorrow morning for review before presenting it to the full committee on Wednesday.

CLA Report Follow-Up Discussion

The group also discussed a CLA report response, deciding to present it as a draft to the full committee while gathering additional data to fill in gaps with a vote of 4-0-1.

Enrollment Forecasting and Report Updates and Discussion

The subcommittee discussed enrollment forecasting, with Cliff presenting a document summarizing previous conversations and recommendations for periodic updates. Mariah suggested refining terminology and offered to make edits to the document.

School Subcommittee Final Report Discussion

The group also touched on the override numbers, which Bella will present at the next meeting. The team agreed to discuss the override numbers with the full E&RSC and not in the Subcommittee meeting.

Sadaf outlined the timeline for completing various reports and documents, including the town school financial model and the CLA report. Dick suggested using a consistent formatting style for the reports, which Sadaf agreed to share with the group.

New Business

Mariah mentioned needing to follow up on a previous recommendation regarding temperature control.

High School Teacher Workload Summary by Comparable District

Mariah Nobrega, prepared for Brookline Expenditures and Revenues Committee's Schools Subcommittee, presented January 12, 2026, *Updated February 1, 2026 with strikeout in paragraph 1 and footnote on page 1. Updated February 28, 2026 with additional info for Belmont, Newton and Natick.*

Analysis background: Brookline High School has a "4+1" non-contractual¹ practice in which educators teach four subjects in their area of instruction, and are assigned a fifth academic duty, such as tutorial (executive functioning support for general education students), ~~advisory (small group non-academic support)~~, etc.

Analysis request: To understand whether this level of workload is common in other districts.

To answer this question, I first reached out to the Massachusetts Association of School Committees (MASC) to see if there was any existing research on this. MASC directed me to DESE, but I did not get a response. Next, I reviewed (with the assistance of an AI tool but I validated all information) the contracts of Brookline's "comparable districts" as determined by DESE.

Analysis summary: Of Brookline's comparable districts, all except for Watertown have a similar contractual cap of number of courses taught and/or number of students taught. There are some slight variations, e.g.:

- Acton-Boxborough, Milton and Wellesley have limits on the number of teaching periods per day rather than courses taught per semester or year, but are similarly set at 4 or 5 courses.
- Cambridge has set hours teaching per day rather than courses taught, but is 75% of the day, which is similar to Brookline.

Watertown's contract, which specifies teaching 6 of 7 periods per day, is less aligned with the other districts.

Links to contracts, and snippets of the most relevant language are below.

Acton-Boxborough 2023-2026 ([link](#))

- "Academic subject area junior and senior high school teachers will not be assigned to more than five (5) single teaching periods per day unless agreed upon with the teacher. Senior high school English teachers will not be assigned to more than four (4) single teaching periods plus one (1) duty per day unless agreed upon with the teacher." p19-20
- [Class size:] The desirable maximum number of students per teacher is as follows...Junior and Senior High Schools...Academic Subjects 25" p22

Arlington 2024-2027 ([link](#))

- "Combined totals in educator's regular classes in secondary schools (based on a five-day week): Classes in other than English - 125, English classes - 100" p19
- "The teaching loads at the middle and high school will be as follows: a. English teachers: four periods per day (20 per week) Subjects other than English: five periods per day (25 per week)" "Effective August 31, 2006 English teachers may be assigned five periods per day." p20

¹ Revision 2/1/26: There are some aspects in the contract. 1: "It is the goal of the BSC that no full-time high school teachers in Social Studies, Math or Foreign Language shall have an aggregate student load of more than 115 students. If on November 1, such a teacher has a student load in excess of 115, the Head of School shall make efforts to reduce such load to 115." 2: "Grades 9-12 teachers shall have a maximum of twenty (20) assigned instructional periods and four (4) periods of other assigned duties (one of which may be a homeroom), except as the BSC has previously voted otherwise."

Belmont 2022-2025 ([link](#))

- "Whenever it is administratively possible and economically feasible...The maximum pupil load for High School teachers in the major academic areas (i.e., English, World Languages, Mathematics, Science, and Social Studies) shall be 125 students per teacher" p17
- "On the basis of a seven-period day, High School teachers working in the major academic areas will be assigned no more than thirty (30) periods per week, of which not more than twenty-five (25) shall be teaching periods." p18

Cambridge 2023-2026 ([link](#))

- "High school teachers shall teach 75% of the instructional day for students." p16
- "[Class size]: It is agreed that as soon as practical, considering availability of qualified personnel and suitable classroom space, the maximum number of pupils per teacher will be as follows...Senior High School...Academic subjects 28" p20

Lexington 2023-2026 ([link](#))

- "The teaching load for the length of this contract will not exceed 125 students/1 teacher. English is an exception with its cap held to the nationally recommended maximum ratio of 100 students/1 teacher. By September 1, 2027, all teachers who work in grades 6-12 will have a caseload of up to 100-105" p15

Milton 2022-2025 ([link](#))

- "Wherever possible, high school teachers will not be required to teach more than an average of five (5) classes per day" p10
- "Wherever possible, high school teachers will not be assigned more than four (4) teaching periods per day or three (3) teaching periods and one (1) administrative duty period per day per schedule cycle" p10
- "Wherever possible, no academic class will exceed twenty-five (25) students" p10
- "Whenever the total number of students assigned to a teacher exceeds one hundred-thirty (130), the teacher will be granted relief from their duty" p10

Newton 2024-2027 ([link](#))

- "It is understood and agreed that the decision with respect to class size and pupil staff ratio is within the exclusive judgment and discretion of the Committee." p29
- "Teachers of English, English Language Learners, History and Social Science, Mathematics, Science, Engineering, and World Language shall be required to teach four (4) year-long classes or the equivalent. Special education teachers teaching a full load of courses or supporting students in the above subject areas will also teach four (4) classes or the equivalent. All other teachers shall teach five (5) classes or the equivalent" p97
- "Beginning with the 2023-2024 school year, the parties agree that all full-time high school English teachers will be capped at 264 students (22 students average class size) over a three(3)-year period" p99

Natick 2025-2028 ([link](#))

- "[T]he parties accept the following class maxima: ...Senior High Schools 25 Students per educator ... High School Caseload 125 Students." p17-18
- "However, failure to reach these class sizes shall not be subject to the grievance and arbitration provisions of this Agreement." p17-18

Watertown 2023-2025 ([link](#))

- “All Middle School and Senior High School teachers will not be assigned more than seven (7) periods per day, consisting of at least one (1) full and uninterrupted preparation period and not more than six (6) student supervision periods...Academic subject area Middle and Senior High School teachers will not be required to teach more than two (2) subjects, nor prepare for more than three (3) specific course designations per day.” p18

Wellesley 2023-2026 ([link](#))

- “High School teachers will not be assigned more than four (4) classes per day” p9
- "No teacher shall, at any given time, be assigned the class responsibility, regardless of the size of their classes, for more than one hundred twenty-five (125) pupils" p13

More information on Brookline High School Teacher Workload

Mariah Nobrega, prepared for Brookline Expenditures and Revenues Committee's Schools Subcommittee, presented February 2, 2026.

Following the earlier discussion on workload comparisons by district and the contractual language of 115 in the Unit A contract, I requested information from BHS leadership on workload: (1) what the +1 component consists of and (2) how workload compares to the 115 students in the contract. ("It is the goal of the BSC that no full-time high school teachers in Social Studies, Math or Foreign Language shall have an aggregate student load of more than 115 students. If on November 1, such a teacher has a student load in excess of 115, the Head of School shall make efforts to reduce such load to 115.")

1. Plus One Assignments

The +1 assignments of full time staff in MA, SC, SO and WL are:

49	Tutorial
9	Second teacher in WL classes
9	Extra lab periods for AP Science
4	Math Center
5	Calculus Support
1	Queer Student Program
2	Teacher Mentors
2	Language Center/Support

Advisory is not a plus one assignment-- advisory is a community duty and not part of the teaching load.

2. Average of student load

Data is shown on the next page for the full-time teaching staff in the five core academic subjects (not just the 3 – Social Studies, Math, World Language – in the contract.) A few notes:

- These totals do not include their +1 assignment. The numbers in Tutorial would add between 5 and 10 students per teacher.
- If PSB ended +1 then there would be many teachers over the 115 as we compose classes now.
- The language in the contract on Student Load apparently predates the late 90s/early 00s, when the staffing model was changed.

2025-26 Brookline HS Teaching Loads for Full-Time Staff by Academic Subject

position	load	position	load	position	load	position	load	position	load
English 1	91	Math 1	89	Science 1	95	Social Studies 1	96	WL 1	94
English 2	94	Math 2	90	Science 2	87	Social Studies 2	91	WL 2	79
English 3	78	Math 3	103	Science 3	94	Social Studies 3	90	WL 3	79
English 4	93	Math 4	95	Science 4	94	Social Studies 4	79	WL 4	69
English 5	78	Math 5	92	Science 6	86	Social Studies 5	95	WL 5	77
English 6	104	Math 6	89	Science 7	82	Social Studies 6	101	WL 6	79
English 7	76	Math 7	80	Science 8	96	Social Studies 7	93	WL 7	87
English 8	73	Math 8	105	Science 9	92	Social Studies 8	101	WL 8	78
English 9	98	Math 9	110	Science 10	88	Social Studies 9	90	WL 9	79
English 10	68	Math 10	86	Science 11	71	Social Studies 10	95	WL 10	92
English 11	94	Math 11	106	Science 12	81	Social Studies 11	90	WL 11	96
English 12	95	Math 12	102	Science 13	84	Social Studies 12	101	WL 12	80
English 13	102	Math 13	90	Science 14	88	Social Studies 13	85	WL 13	83
English 14	87	Math 14	94	Science 15	92	Social Studies 14	86	WL 14	69
English 15	90	Math 15	75	Science 16	90	Social Studies 15	91	WL 15	87
English 16	99	Math 16	110	Science 17	93	Social Studies 16	98	WL 16	89
		Math 17	90	Science 18	76	Social Studies 17	91	WL 17	75
		Math 18	92	Science 19	91			WL 18	80
		Math 19	63	Science 20	88			WL 19	94
				Science 21	87				
				Science 22	87				
				Science 23	97				
Average EN	88.8	MA	92.7	SC	88.1	SO	92.5	WL	82.4

Enrollment Forecasts

Accurate enrollment forecasts are critical for planning and budgeting purposes. Even before the shock of COVID-19, years of flawed methodologies led to a period of underestimating future enrollment followed by a period of overestimating future enrollment. This roller-coaster created an environment in which the PSB and the Town were in a constant reactive state, making annual and longer-term planning difficult.

No long-range forecast will ever be 100% correct and the longer the forecast, the less reliable the numbers in the ‘out-years’ will be. On the other hand, one-year forecasts, which may have a high degree of accuracy, do not provide any guidance that can be used to develop intermediate to longer term operational or capital planning.

Brookline has the additional challenge of having a highly transient population. Because the Town has many rental properties and because Brookline has long been a preferred location for international graduate students and professionals coming to the area for shorter-term assignments or training, the PSB experiences an extraordinary amount of ‘churn’. Churn is turnover in the student population and includes new students moving into Town, existing students moving out of Town and existing students moving to a different part of Town. The latest DESE data¹ shows that among DESE-identified peer districts, Brookline is third for churn, behind only Cambridge and Watertown, as well as for intake (students who enroll after the start of the school year), another hallmark of the highly transient population.

Recent Models used by PSB

In 2019, the PSB retained the firm of Cropper-McKibben to provide a long-range demographic and enrollment forecast². With the onset of COVID, the assumptions of this report were quickly invalidated. Given the unprecedented situation, the PSB utilized ad-hoc enrollment estimates incorporating historic data of enrollment of international students, cohort survival rates and assumptions around the possibility that initial COVID-influenced enrollment changes due to travel and Visa restrictions would trend back to historic levels.

¹ <https://profiles.doe.mass.edu/statereport/mobilityrates.aspx>

² <https://www.psbma.org/fs/resource-manager/view/dd07d2e0-d914-4898-b25e-00eb975e567f>

In 2023, the PSB hired Cropper-McKibben to update the previous demographic/enrollment report³. The forecast (see summary table below) showed a gradual reduction of students, to a low in 2027-28, followed by an increase over the next six years, but still at a level more than 5% below the 2018-19 pre-pandemic peak of 7,855.

Actual Data						Projected by Cropper McKibben ⁴									
	19-20	20-21	21-22	22-23	23-24	24-25	25-26	26-27	27-28	28-29	29-30	30-31	31-32	32-33	33-34
Pre-K	252	144	255	257	256	256	256	256	256	256	256	256	256	256	256
Total K-8	5,446	4,703	4,586	4,716	4,610	4,581	4,611	4,588	4,635	4,659	4,684	4,733	4,827	4,955	5,075
Total 9-12	2,064	2,017	2,063	2,066	2,155	2,143	2,062	2,073	1,995	2,018	2,110	2,129	2,162	2,133	2,113
Total K-12	7,510	6,720	6,649	6,782	6,765	6,724	6,673	6,661	6,630	6,677	6,794	6,862	6,989	7,088	7,188
Total Pre-K-12	7,762	6,864	6,904	7,039	7,021	6,980	6,929	6,917	6,886	6,933	7,050	7,118	7,245	7,344	7,444

Most recently (last year for 2025-26 and this year for 2026-27), for year-to-year enrollment projections, PSB has used the following methodology: for kindergarten, the enrollment figure for the incoming class was the arithmetic average of the class size for the prior three school years. For grades 1-12, the projected class size was the average 3-year survival rate applied to the prior year advancing class. For example, for 2025-26 8th grade, it would be the number of children in the 2024-25 7th grade multiplied by the average survival rate of the 7th grade cohorts that moved to the 8th grade in 2022-23, 2023-24 and 2024-25.

This model does have a reasonable level of accuracy for a one-year period. However, it is retrospective, with no consideration given to structural or demographic information that can provide guidance for how the Town and PSB should plan. The most obvious data ignored is new residential construction, which will almost always result in additional school-aged children in the district where construction occurs. Other issues include changing demographics, changing birth rates, changing economic environments, changing political environment, etc. Some of these topics are dealt with in the demographic forecast provided by Cropper-McKibben. The district has not yet attempted to explicitly include the data in its planning or determined whether it is possible, or useful, to use the data in its short-term model.

³ <https://www.psbma.org/fs/resource-manager/view/e33b9111-f183-4cb8-8bd2-10748ca98a3e>

⁴ For 2024-2025, actual enrollment was 7,023, meaning Cropper-McKibben was within 1% of actual. In 2025-2026, actual enrollment was 6,948, again meaning that Cropper-McKibben was within 1% of actual.

Subcommittee Views and Recommendations

Retrospective methodologies contributed to Brookline being caught off-guard by the prior (pre-COVID) enrollment boom. The subcommittee does not believe the PSB can, or should, rely solely on the methodology it currently employs and that it needs to both use the longer-term forecast for “what-if” scenarios/planning, and, if possible, incorporate some of the assumptions into its short-term models. Cropper-McKibben or another similar vendor should also be retained on a routine (every 3 years) basis to update the long-term forecast; the subcommittee understands that the School Committee and staff have discussed this and reached the same conclusion, though to our knowledge no firm has yet been retained. Our recommendation is that the PSB commit to this recommendation, via School Committee policy.

Schools Subcommittee Recommendation Summary – DRAFT for discussion on 3/2/26

The Schools Subcommittee began work in earnest in October 2025, but with limited information on the PSB's three-year financials. A strictly bottom line forecast (meaning no details behind the data) for FY27-31 was shared on November 13th, 2025. Refinements to the FY27-29 forecasts were not shared until December 18, 2025, and January 22, 2026. The FY27 PSB Budget Book was published on February 5, 2026. (this may belong in the full report summary instead)

The delay in obtaining detailed information and capacity constraints within the PSB central office has limited the Schools Subcommittee ability to do a 'dive deep' into the PSB forecasts.

Because this delay constrained the Subcommittee's ability to thoroughly analyze options related to a proposed override number until late February, the Subcommittee focused its efforts on areas it could analyze without meaningful support from PSB staff. The following recommendations and the detailed School Subcommittee report later in this document are scoped based on this effort and are therefore limited in details regarding the actual FY27-29 forecasts. All recommendations were voted on and approved by both the School Subcommittee and the full E&RSC.

Overall School Subcommittee recommendation

There is skepticism among some Brookline residents about the financial management of the Schools. While this skepticism has a long history, it was compounded by several events including the budgeting process undertaken for FY26, the departure of key district leaders who made accusations about financial mismanagement in the district, and the outcome of the CLA report. While many of the allegations were not substantiated these incidents have nonetheless negatively impacted community sentiment about the Schools.

We appreciate the extraordinarily difficult circumstances Superintendent Wong inherited when she arrived. Like many in the community, we were relieved when Dr. Wong agreed to come out of retirement and commit to leading the PSB for four years. We are also encouraged by the individuals Dr. Wong has to date added to the district's senior leadership team. This team has demonstrated an ability to make difficult decisions, be open-minded, and to think creatively with an eye to the future. These qualities are evidenced in the proposed FY27 budget which includes a net reduction of 22.1 FTE to right size staffing due to lower enrollment numbers, and by opening the district's special education programs to tuition-paying out-of-district students. The latter has been discussed, but not acted on, for a number of years and was raised early on by this Subcommittee. Our overall recommendation seeks to address not only the question of an override to cover financial gaps in the PSB FY27-29 budgets, but also to ensure that the Schools are working towards an improved cost structure over the next three years and beyond.

Though we are sympathetic to the plight of the Schools and are prepared to support an override request of [xxxx], we can only recommend an override to the Select Board if the School Committee and the PSB commit to the Select Board that they will undertake the following efforts to achieve a better cost structure, improve financial sustainability, and thereby help rebuild community confidence in the School Committee and the PSB at the end of this override cycle:

1. Develop a plan in collaboration with Town administration to negotiate a reduced healthcare premium contribution by the Town for its employees, to bring this contribution in alignment with comparable communities by [MM/DD/YYYY].
2. Create an approach through which the schools will manage wage expenses to not exceed projected year-over-year revenue growth, including considering caps on wage increases or other creative contractual terms.
3. Evaluate an updated school model, including a possible middle school model or more robust classroom consolidation with possible redistricting, starting in FY27.
4. Complete the work included in the Town/School MOU dated October 2025 with respect to using MUNIS as the townwide financial system of record, and resolving any gaps needed to ensure that PSB is able to use MUNIS effectively by the end of [2027].
5. Agree that all third-party users of space in school buildings between the hours of xx:00AM and 5:30 PM enter into fair market rate rental agreements including reimbursement for maintenance and utility costs.

[Additional items to consider adding to this list]

6. Study the usage of technology in our classrooms to ensure that it serves its educational purpose and is needed for our educational objectives at each grade level - use this to evaluate the cost of hardware leases, and educational technology subscriptions. [refine after 3/2 meeting]
7. Migrate to teaching loads closer to current contractual limits at BHS [complete after our 3/2 meeting]

Summary of recommendations by Subcommittee workstream

Below is a summary of all the recommendations made by the Schools Subcommittee and voted on by the Subcommittee and the full E&RSC.

Cost avoidance and expenditure reduction recommendations

1. Benefits cost structure improvement: Medical insurance premiums have been identified as a “budget buster” for the Town and Schools. The 83% employer share of medical insurance premiums paid by the Town and Schools is one of the most generous of comparable communities. Reducing Brookline’s contribution rate to a level in line with similar communities would result in savings of millions of dollars per year, permitting a smaller override and increasing the likelihood that an override will be palatable to the voters. The Select Board should consider an override amount that is calculated based on a reduced medical insurance premium employer contribution rate, with an effective date by which savings from that reduced rate would be expected to be realized. See section X for the full report.

2. Salaries, steps and lanes, and COLA. As the Select Board considers the amount of an override to be added to the 5.1% property tax increase that will occur in FY27 even without an override, it should consider the following:

- Approximately one-half of Public Schools of Brookline (PSB) educators receive “step” increases in addition to contractual cost-of-living increases. The impact of steps increases actual salaries by an amount well beyond the nominal cost-of-living (COLA) increase and actual inflation. Some Town employees also receive step increases.
- Although detailed comparisons to other communities would consider total compensation and benefit packages, as well as working conditions and the existence of actual employment opportunities, all of which PSB should consider, major elements that have been analyzed (base compensation, health benefits, teaching load) indicate that Brookline’s total package compares favorably to other communities.
- In response to questions posed by the E&RSC Schools Subcommittee, PSB identified eleven school districts that were similar to Brookline. Boston and Cambridge, though not deemed similar by PSB, were added to an analysis of salaries because of geographic proximity. That analysis – across a broad range of “steps” (i.e., seniority) and a broad range of “lanes” (degree attained) – demonstrates that salaries for Brookline educators are thousands of dollars more than the median salaries in those districts, with the single exception of long-term educators with doctorate degrees.
- As reported in another analysis, the employer contribution rate for health insurance in Brookline exceeds that of other communities. Brookline High School educators are required to teach only four classes per day, with one other assigned duty, a teaching load that is no more, and often less, demanding than comparable school districts.
- Any override will be in addition to the 5.1% increase in property taxes that is already projected to occur in the absence of an override.
- The current salary structure including the impact of “step” increases in addition to nominal COLA increases, along with other costs such as health insurance that are increasing over time, will be unsustainable over time without a cycle of repeated overrides. PSB and the School Committee should recognize the total financial impact of the salary structure which, as noted, can generate individual wage increases of up to 8% when the nominal contractual COLA increase is only 2.75% and inflation is only slightly more than 3%.
- While the goal is to compensate School (and Town) competitively, this must be done in a manner that is sustainable over time without the expectation of continuing overrides.

3. Special education funding for non-resident students (final recommendations not yet voted)

Revenue increasing recommendations

1. Recreation facilities rentals: Conduct a pilot program run by the Brookline Recreation department beginning July 1, 2026, running through June 30, 2027, to test a more coherent model of facilities governance and youth athletics coordination. The pilot would allow the Town to test a better system in a controlled, data-driven way—demonstrating whether improved governance can simultaneously strengthen youth development, reduce fragmentation, and improve fiscal stewardship. If successful, the model could be expanded to non-recreation facilities such as parking. At a high level, this pilot would:

1. Designate one or two facilities (e.g., Runkle, FRR and/or Driscoll) for unified oversight. Establish clear rules for access, pricing, scheduling, and accountability.

2. Prioritize Brookline youth and schools while transparently managing external and adult use.
3. Track utilization, revenue, equity of access, and community outcomes.
4. Via agreement, ensure the needs of the PSB with respect to:
 - building control during the school day (including extended day),
 - ability to reserve space for identified special events at the beginning of the school year and during the school year with an agreed-upon number of days' notice (e.g. 60),
 - securing the buildings during off-hours by restricting access outside of the facility being rented
 - protecting equipment and the premises and ensuring post-activity clean-up of the facility
 - addressing other matters of concern identified by PSB prior to the commencement of the pilot program.

See section X for the full report (**need to reference overall building management**).

2. BEEP tuition: (**final recommendation not yet voted**)

Additional recommendations (final recommendations not yet voted**)**

1. Town-school financial model
2. CLA report follow-ups
3. Enrollment forecast refinements

School Subcommittee Report Introduction

The following report includes the detailed analysis and reports that culminated in the School Subcommittee recommendations. It is organized into two primary sections in line with the overall mandate of the E&RSC: 1) cost avoidance or expenditure reduction opportunities, and 2) revenue increasing opportunities. In addition, we have included other work undertaken by the School Subcommittee in support of 1 and 2 in a third “other” section.

<<full reports will start here>>

SIZE OF THE OVERRIDE AND CAPACITY TO PAY (3.1.26 Draft) (updated after 2/26/26 School Committee Budget Presentation)

Summary

As the Select Board considers placing an operating override on the ballot, the following factors should lead the Board to carefully scrutinize the size of any proposed override, with sensitivity to the impacts of increased property taxes on owners and renters. The override amount should not impose an onerous burden on residents or, conversely, be unacceptable to voters and result in failure:

- The Town and Schools current override “asks” would result in property taxes increasing by almost 20% from current levels in three years when those “asks” are added to property tax increases already embedded for FY27 to FY29. **There should be full disclosure to the voters of both the aggregate one-year (8.3%) and the three-year (19.3%) impacts.**
- Time periods between Brookline’s operating overrides have recently been compressed, with residents now facing planned overrides every three years. Significant property tax increases have also resulted from debt exclusions, driven largely by almost three-quarters of a billion dollars for school construction, expansion and renovation.
- Even communities that have been cited in support of an override, such as Melrose, Stoneham, and Arlington, do not approach the frequency of overrides seen in Brookline. Moreover, there is a particular lesson to be learned from Stoneham, where voters rejected two larger overrides before accepting a smaller one.
- Brookline’s average single-family property taxes (the data provided by the Department of Revenue, or “DOR”) increased at a much faster rate than those of communities identified by PSB as similar school communities. Brookline’s single-family property taxes increased by \$12,627 (from \$13,610 to \$26,237) between FY15 and FY26, or 229% of the median increase of \$5,524 in the similar school communities.
- And if we look simply at the percentage increase in taxes as reported by the DOR in order to factor out Brookline’s greater property values, Brookline’s single-family property taxes increased by 93% versus a 64% median increase in the similar school communities, or a **rate of increase 146% that of the comparable communities.**
- Utilizing Brookline Assessor’s data, property taxes on **all classes of residential properties** in Brookline (condominium, single-family, two-family, three-family and 4+ unit buildings) **far outstripped the rate of inflation** from FY15 to FY26, at 143% to 265% of the inflation rate for the various residential property types.
- **Renters are not immune from property tax increases**, since the standard Greater Boston lease includes a clause allowing increased property taxes to be passed on directly to renters. In fact, renters in two- and three-family buildings are highly likely to be affected by an override, since tax increases on the building must be borne by a smaller number of units and since the rental units are not eligible for the residential homeowner exemption.

- Brookline **owners and renters** are burdened by housing costs, even without an override further increasing property taxes, with thousands **already paying more than 30% and even 35% of their household incomes for housing** according to 2024 American Community Survey calculations. The impact is **particularly great among seniors** age 65 and over.
- Over 3,300 **owners** faced housing costs greater than 30% of their household incomes, and 2,800 greater than 35%. This included 1,250 seniors (27.2% of senior owners) paying more than 30% of their incomes for housing, and over 1,060 seniors (23.1%) paying more than 35%.
- Over 6,650 **renters** (almost 47%) paid more than 30%, and over 5,300 (37.6%) more than 35%, of their household incomes for housing. The most senior Brookline renters faced the greatest burdens. One-half (49.9%) of senior renters – almost 1,000 -- pay more than 30% of their incomes for rent and utilities, with over 700 (38%) paying more than 35%.
- **Thus, in setting the level of any override it may propose**, the Select Board should carefully scrutinize the necessity of increased Town and School expenditures, be cognizant of the taxes already faced by residents, and be sensitive to the impacts of further tax increases on residents, and particularly senior residents, including consideration of the following as discussed in more detail in the final section of this Report:
 - Spreading portions of the Town and School override “asks” over three years to avoid a significant 8.3% property tax increase in year one of the override.
 - Basing the override amount on a health insurance employer contribution level in line with many comparable communities, rather than accepting the current 83% as a “given” that will persist, while allowing time for a sustainable employer contribution level to be negotiated.
 - Basing the override amount on an overall wage increase of 2.5% or 3%, rather than the 5% that would result under the current PSB salary “grid,” while allowing time for that salary structure to be negotiated. When coupled with the level of health insurance premium costs currently paid by the Town and Schools, along with projected premium increases, a 5% wage increase would result in an unsustainable annual employee compensation increase of approximately 6.8%.
 - Basing the override amount on PSB enforcement of contractual teaching load provisions, which provide for a maximum of 20 assigned instructional periods and 4 periods of other assigned duties per week, through revisions to the “4+1” model. At a minimum, any override should incorporate savings from revisions of the “4+1” model already identified by PSB.
 - Revising the override amount to include the projected savings from the Solar Initiative proposed by the Futures Subcommittee.
 - Incorporating increases in BEEP Extended Day tuition to levels adequate to cover costs, as recommended by the Schools Subcommittee.
- The Select Board could put a single override on the ballot that incorporates the savings described above. It could also offer a “tiered” override. Both tiers could “phase in” Town and School amounts over three years, rather than front-end loading certain

amounts, and also incorporate modifications to the “4+1” system already identified by PSB (a reduction of 6.6 FTEs, or close to \$1 million per year when benefits are included). Both override tiers would preserve Town and School services, rather than finding savings by eliminating fire companies and middle school World Languages. The lower tier would expressly incorporate an employer health insurance contribution rate in line with most similar school communities (saving at least \$3.5 million, and up to \$7.9 million, per year). The lower tier would also incorporate a 2.5% or 3% annual increase in Town and School wages (saving between \$2.5 and \$3 million per year of School wages, plus a further amount in Town wages). The higher override tier would offer voters the choice of continuing to fund the 83% employer contribution rate for health insurance premiums and the existing increases in School salaries of approximately 5% per year as well as Town salary increases, in addition to increases in benefit costs of 12% per year.

- The Town and Schools should implement further recommendations of various E&RSC subcommittees. They should:
 - Conduct a robust review of the BEEP full and extended day tuitions, since programs are being offered for less than market rates and for less than the cost of the programs.
 - Collaborate with other communities, including specifically Newton and Lexington, to lobby for additional METCO funding for in-district Special Education costs that are shifted from student “sending” communities to “receiving” communities.
 - Evaluate the financial and educational benefits and costs of conversion to a middle school model.
 - Implement a pilot program to manage rentals and use of public buildings and facilities, including use by third parties, Town and School departments and not-for-profit organizations.
 - Evaluate and implement, where beneficial, the consolidation of functions serving both the Town and Schools.
 - Evaluate and, where beneficial, amend the Town/School financial model, including the methodology used to assign or “split” revenues, the allocation of costs “above the line” or “below the line,” and the creation of clear working relationships for Town departments and for the Schools regarding the assignment of responsibility, funding and control of costs and services.
 - Proceed with an independent review of the steps taken with regard to the Clifton Larson Allen report on PSB administration.

Discussion

1. The proposed override would result in tax increases of almost 20% in three years.

The Town has proposed an override of \$5,310,000 for Town departments, with the entire Town amount added to property taxes in the first year, FY27. At the February 26, 2026 School Committee Meeting, PSB identified a “3-year funding gap” of \$18,538,687, which was identified as the Schools’ override “ask.” Combined, those figures would result in a total override amount

of \$23.8 million, with the PSB amount presumably phased in over three years. That override amount would be built into the Town's levy limit, and thus subject to the additional 2.5% increases in that levy limit from year to year.

Without an override, property taxes would increase from \$335.9 million in the current year, FY26, to \$375.5 million in FY29, an increase of \$39.6 million or 11.8%.¹ **When the override is added** to already embedded Proposition 2 ½ increases, new growth, and debt exclusions, property taxes would increase to \$400.8 million over the next three years, a **\$64.9 million or 19.3% increase over that period.**

The 8.3% tax impact with the override would be particularly dramatic in FY27, given the Town proposal to add the entire override amount to property taxes in the first year, and the PSB proposal to recapture in one year the entire \$1.9 million in Circuit Breaker funds used to balance the Schools' FY26 budget gap.

¹ The table on page 20 of the FY27 Financial Plan does not appear to include the Community Preservation Act (CPA), which increases property taxes by 1%. The FY26 Levy Limit is found on page 7 of the Financial Plan. FY26 Debt Exclusion debt service costs of \$28,596,860 were presented at the 12/9/25 Select Board meeting. The FY26 property tax total with the CPA is shown on the table. The property tax total for FY29, with no override, is the \$371,761,574 amount on page 20 of the Financial Plan, increased by the 1% CPA tax, or a total of \$375,479,190. Note that the reported percentage increases would not change with the inclusion or exclusion of the 1% CPA tax.

PROPERTY TAXES	FY2026	FY2027	FY2028	FY2029
Prior Year Levy Limit		\$ 303,973,332	\$ 337,921,352	\$ 348,869,386
2 1/2% Increase		\$ 7,599,333	\$ 8,448,034	\$ 8,721,735
New Growth		\$ 2,500,000	\$ 2,500,000	\$ 2,500,000
General Override		\$ 23,848,687		
LEVY LIMIT	\$ 303,973,332	\$ 337,921,352	\$ 348,869,386	\$ 360,091,121
Unused Override		\$ 13,270,083	\$ 7,762,951	\$ -
PROPERTY TAX Subtotal		\$ 324,651,269	\$ 341,106,435	\$ 360,091,121
Debt Exclusion	\$ 28,596,860	\$ 35,379,833	\$ 36,013,706	\$ 36,726,580
ANNUAL LEVY BEFORE CPA	\$ 332,570,192	\$ 360,031,102	\$ 377,120,141	\$ 396,817,701
CPA at 1%	\$ 3,325,702	\$ 3,600,311	\$ 3,771,201	\$ 3,968,177
TOTAL WITH CPA	\$ 335,895,894	\$ 363,631,413	\$ 380,891,343	\$ 400,785,878
\$ Increase from prior		\$ 27,735,519	\$ 17,259,929	\$ 19,894,535
% Increase from prior		8.3%	4.7%	5.2%
\$ Increase from FY26		\$ 27,735,519	\$ 44,995,449	\$ 64,889,984
% Increase from FY26		8.3%	13.4%	19.3%
Sources: For Town, FY-2027 Financial Plan, pp. 6, 25 (FY26 levy limit, \$5,310,000 override levy in FY27). For Schools, School Committee Presentation 2/26/26 (3-year funding gap \$18,538,687; annual FY27, 28, 29 figures used for assumed "phase in"); chrome-extension://efaidnbmninnibpcjpcglclefindmkaj/https://resources.finalsite.net/images/v1772150122/brooklinek12maus/raxvb5dsv1h2ge4rkgti/FY27BudgetUpdate_nonORListSC22626.pdf				

2. Property tax overrides have accelerated in Brookline in recent years, in addition to nearly three-quarters of a billion dollars in debt exclusions for schools.

Brookline has recently moved into a pattern of frequent overrides, with this proposed override coming hard on the heels of the 2023 override and the suggestion of yet another override in 2029. Thus, after Proposition 2½ was enacted in 1980, Brookline waited 14 years for its first override in 1994, and then another 14 years for the second override in 2008. There were then operating override votes in 2015 (a 7-year gap), 2018 (the only prior 3-year gap), and 2023 (a 5-year gap). The proposal for another operating override vote in 2026, only three years after the previous override, and the suggestion that an override in 2026 will be followed by another in 2029, significantly accelerates the historical norms.

Taxes have, moreover, been raised by “debt exclusions,” primarily for the public schools: 1990 (new Lincoln school - \$88 million); 1995 (High School repairs - \$41 million); 2015

(expand and renovate Devotion/Florida Ruffin Ridley school - \$88 million after MSBA reimbursement); 2018 (renovate and expand High School - \$237 million); 2019 (new Driscoll school - \$120 million); 2020 (Newbury College land purchase - \$14.9 million); 2022 (fire station renovations - \$60 million); and 2023 (new Pierce school – at least \$172 million, assuming full MSBA reimbursement). The debt exclusions for school buildings, even assuming full MSBA reimbursement, has totaled \$726 million, almost ten times the \$75 million in debt exclusions approved for other Town purposes.

The impact of the overrides and debt exclusions can be seen in the later sections of this report.

3. The experience in other Massachusetts communities underscores that the requested override amount should be reduced, and that voters should be offered the option of voting for a more modest override.

The FY27 Financial Plan states on page 24 that the override proposal is “consistent with what is happening across Massachusetts,” pointing to overrides that passed in Melrose and Stoneham. In actuality, those communities – and the experience of communities “across Massachusetts” – tell a different story.²

The Melrose override passed in 2025, but the previous successful Melrose override was **six years earlier** in 2019, and the only successful override prior to that was **twenty-seven years** before that, in 1992. Voters defeated overrides eight times between 1991 and 2025. Melrose is hardly on the cycle of overrides every three years that is now on the table for Brookline.

The Stoneham override for \$9.3 million passed on 12/9/25 at the same election at which a larger \$12.5 million override was **defeated**, and eight months after a \$14.6 million override was also **defeated**. Stoneham’s experience thus sends a lesson that voters should be offered a moderate override, or **a multi-level or “tiered” override, rather than a single daunting “take it or leave it” amount.**

The Financial Plan also cites a proposed override in Arlington. Whether or not that override passes, it should, as with Melrose and Stoneham, be considered against the past history of that community. As graphically pictured in the next section, Department of Revenue figures report that taxes on the average single-family home in Arlington increased by \$4,641 or 63.5%

² Historical data for overrides in Massachusetts communities is reported at https://dls-gw.dor.state.ma.us/reports/rdpage.aspx?rdreport=votes.prop2_5.overrideunderride

from FY15 to FY26, while those in Brookline increased by \$12,627 or 92.8%, **a rate of increase 146% of the rate of increase in Arlington.**

Finally, with respect to the success of overrides “across Massachusetts” in these difficult financial times, for Fiscal Years 2025 to 2027 the Department of Revenue reports 60 operating override “wins” and 68 operating override “losses” in Massachusetts communities. This hardly demonstrates a history of successful overrides “across Massachusetts,” a sobering message for consideration.

4. Brookline’s residential property taxes have accelerated at a much faster rate than taxes in comparable communities.

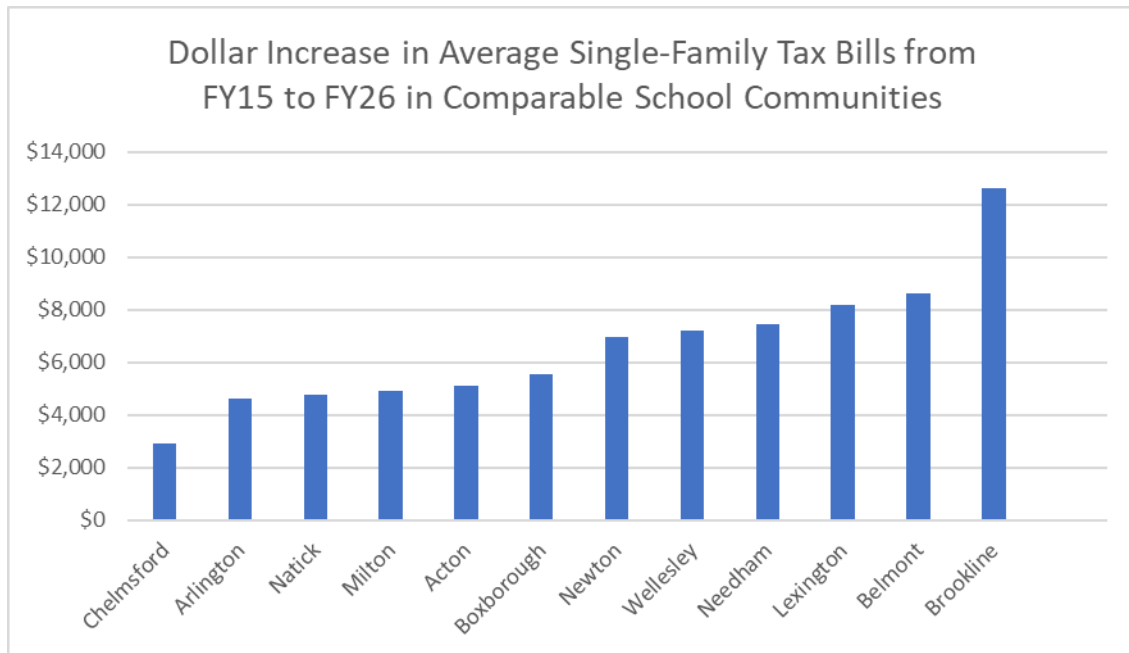
In responses to questions posed by the Expenditure & Revenue Study Committee (E&RSC), the Public Schools of Brookline (PSB) identified eleven school districts that the PSB considers similar to Brookline for purposes of benchmarking. The following analysis focuses on the residential property tax history of those communities.

The bottom-line impact can be viewed through a number of lenses, including Massachusetts Department of Revenue (DOR) data and data from the Brookline Assessor.

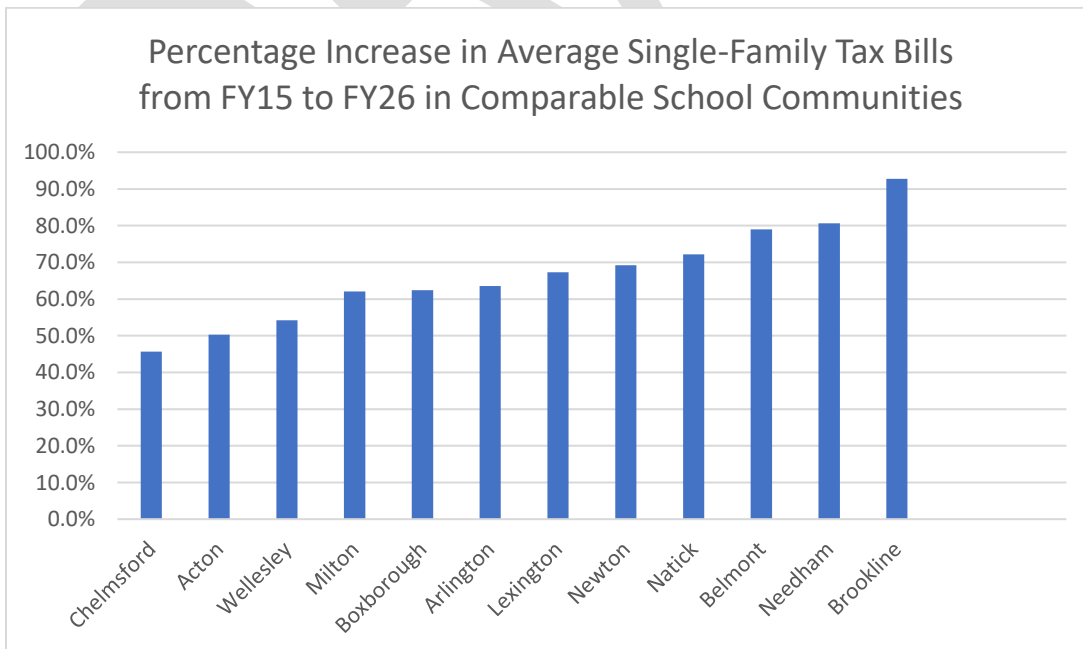
The Massachusetts Department of Revenue (DOR) provides data showing the taxes over time on an average single-family home in each community in the State. This allows us to look at the actual increases over time in single-family property taxes between FY15 and FY26 in communities that the PSB identified as comparable.³

The increase in the dollar amount of average single-family taxes in Brookline and the comparable communities shows the dramatic increases in Brookline taxes. Brookline’s average single-family tax bill increased by \$12,627 (from \$13,610 to \$26,237) between FY15 and FY26, which is 229% (**well over two times**) the median increase of \$5,524 in the comparable school communities.

³ https://dls-gw.dor.state.ma.us/reports/rdPage.aspx?rdReport=AverageSingleTaxBill.SingleFamTaxBill_wRange
The comparable school communities were identified by PSB in the discussion of out-of-district placements on page 8 of the PSB response to questions posed by the E&RSC, as provided to the E&RSC in a July 2, 2025 Memorandum from School Committee members Sarah Moghtader and Jesse Hefter. Watertown is not presented in the graphs because the DOR does not report its average 2015 single-family tax. The combined Acton-Boxborough district is represented by the two municipalities. The average 2015 single-family tax for Brookline is taken from the Town of Brookline’s January 6, 2015 “Growth in the Cost of Government” report. chrome-extension://efaidnbmnnnibpcajpcglclefindmkaj/https://www.brooklinema.gov/DocumentCenter/View/6783/Cost-of-Government---Growth-and-Comparables--Deputy-Town-Administrator-Presentation-1-6-2015-PDF#:~:text=Page%20eligible%20for%20the%20Residential%20Exemption.
The DOR figures do not include the additional impact of the Community Preservation Act in municipalities such as Brookline that add the CPA to tax bills.



It could be argued that Brookline's single-family homes are assessed at higher levels than other communities so the greater tax increases on a dollar basis are unsurprising, but Brookline's tax increases even on a percentage basis substantially exceed those of the similar school communities. The **percentage** increase in the average single-family tax bill in Brookline was 92.8%, while the median for the comparable communities was only 63.5%. In other words, Brookline's taxes increased at a rate that was **146% the rate of the comparable communities**.



It has also been argued that the increase in Brookline's residential taxes can be attributed to Brookline's reliance on residential rather than commercial property taxes, particularly with recent changes in relative value between residential and commercial properties.⁴ However, six of the eleven comparable communities actually have a higher FY26 residential levy percentage than Brookline, with none of the communities benefitting from a significantly greater commercial levy, yet no comparable community matches the tax escalation in Brookline on either a dollar or a percentage basis.⁵

5. Tax increases on all residential buildings in Brookline have outstripped inflation, with taxes on all except condominiums more than double the inflation rate.

While the DOR only provides property tax data for the average single-family property, the Brookline Assessor provides an annual calculation of the median tax on five different residential property classes: condominiums, single-family, 2-family, 3-family and 4+unit buildings. An additional 1% Community Preservation Act tax was approved in 2021.⁶

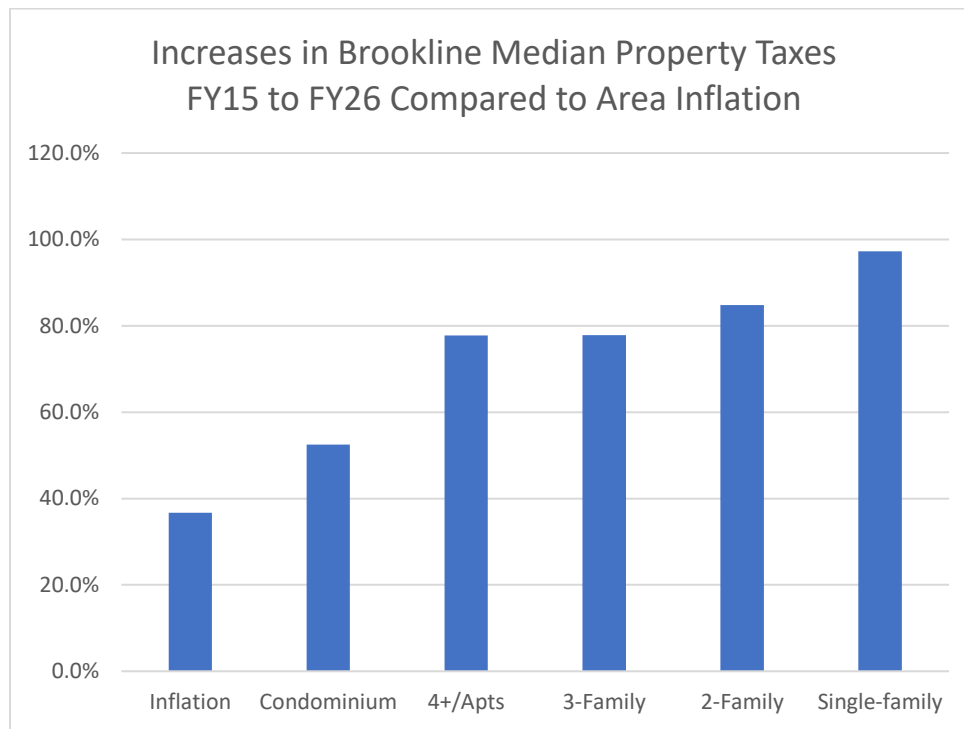
Brookline's property taxes on all classes of residential property have escalated at a rate far exceeding the rate of inflation. While area inflation increased by 36.7% between FY15 and FY26, even the residential class realizing the greatest benefit from the residential exemption, condominiums, saw its property taxes increase by more than 52.5%, or **143% of the increase in inflation** over the same period. The increase on 2-family (84.8%), 3-family (77.8%), and 4+/unit (77.8%) buildings was even more striking – more than **double the increase in inflation**. And

⁴ Under Prop 2.5 where a municipality's total increase in real estate taxes is limited to 2.5% per year (absent new growth, overrides and debt exclusions) relative changes in value between components (residential, commercial, industrial, or between different types of residential properties) will result in year-to-year changes in the percentage of overall taxes one sector must pay.

⁵ Approximately 84% of Brookline's property tax levy in FY26 was residential properties. In ascending order, the FY26 residential levy percentage in the comparable communities was: Lexington 78%, Needham 79%, Natick 83%, Chelmsford 83%, Boxborough 84%, Brookline 84%, Newton 86%, Wellesley 90%, Acton 90%, Milton 93%, Belmont 95%, and Arlington 95%. <https://dls-gw.dor.state.ma.us/reports/rdPage.aspx?rdReport=Dashboard.TrendAnalysisReports.TaxLevyByClass>

⁶ Sources: Tax Classification Hearings (assumes the residential exemption), Select Board Meetings 12/1/15; 11/4/25; 11/18/25. Bureau of Labor Statistics, CPI-U, Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers, Boston-Cambridge-Newton, MA-NH; January 2015 to November 2025 (1982-84=100). The additional Brookline 1% CPA tax was approved in May, 2021 and is included.

the 97.2% increase in property taxes on the median single-family dwelling **was 265% of the increase in inflation.**



Putting these percentage increases into stark dollar terms, the median single-family home tax rose from \$10,704 in FY15 to \$21,113 in FY26, an increase of \$10,409. If taxes had been limited to the area inflation rate, those taxes would only have gone from \$10,704 to \$14,632, or about \$6,500 less than they actually rose.

Similarly, taxes on 2-family and 3-family homes increased by \$8,776 and \$9,006, respectively. Tax increases on these properties are most likely to directly affect renters, since tax hikes must be borne by a limited number of units in a building and the residential exemption would not apply to those rental units.

The foregoing analysis of the impacts on **properties** brings us to the existing burden of housing costs on **people** – the Brookline residents who have faced the impact of tax increases in the past and face the prospect of further tax increases in the future.

6. Thousands of Brookline residents – including senior owners and senior renters in particular -- are already burdened by housing costs, even before additional tax increases.

The accepted rule of thumb for housing affordability is the expenditure of 30% or more of household income on housing. The American Community Survey (ACS) provides not only the percentage of owners and the percentage of renters by age group spending more than 30% of their incomes on housing, but also the percentages spending an even greater amount, more than 35%. The figures presented here are based on the most recently available ACS 2024 5-year estimates -- using data for January 1, 2020 to December 31, 2024. These figures do not include later tax increases, including a \$17.6 million increase in the residential levy between FY25 and FY26,⁷ or a 5.1% property tax increase projected for FY27 even without an override.⁸

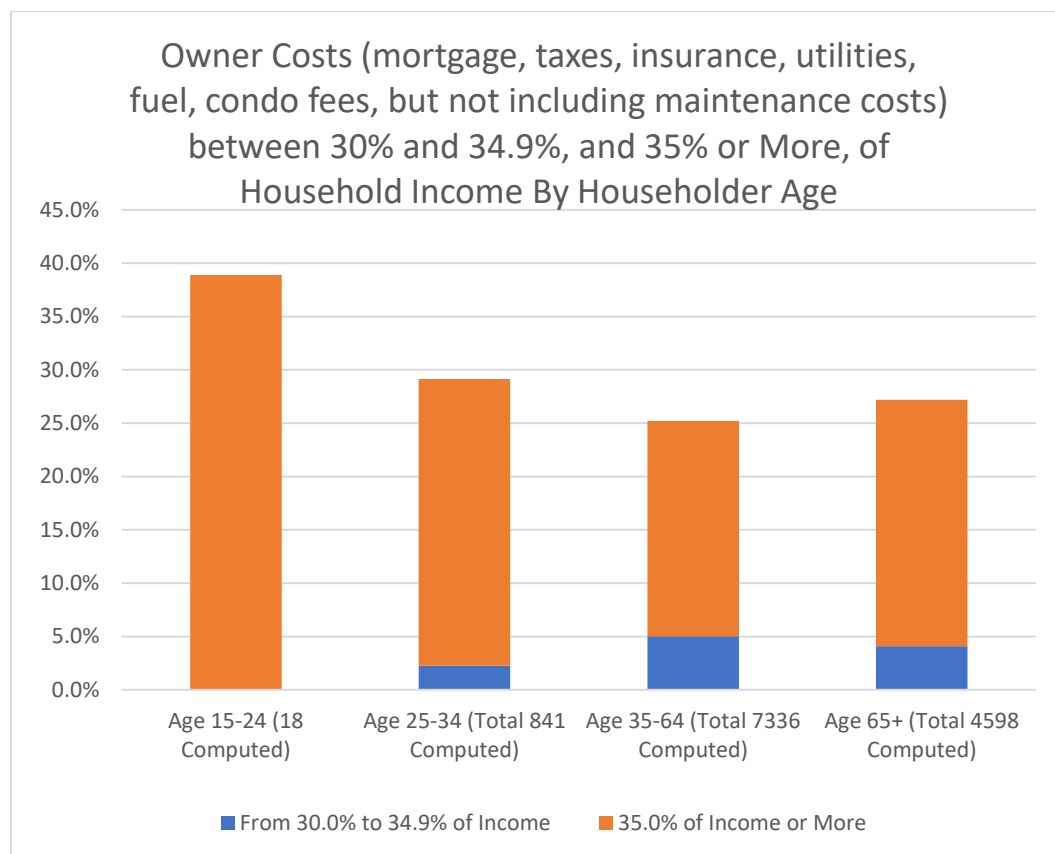
Owners. As shown graphically below, over one-quarter of owners in Brookline were estimated in 2024 to be paying more 30% of their income for housing costs, including mortgage costs, taxes, insurance, utilities, fuel and, where applicable, condominium fees. These figures do not include separate maintenance costs, which can of course be substantial for owners. That is a total of **over 3,300 owners** (26.2%). Most of those – or **almost 2,800 owners** (21.7%) – paid more than 35% of their incomes in owner costs, not including more recent increases. This pattern of housing costs exceeding 35%, not just 30%, of household incomes carries across owners and renters, and across all age groups including seniors in particular.

Despite the assumption that senior owners would be less burdened than younger owners with housing costs because they have already retired their mortgages, the percentage of cost-burdened senior owners is actually **higher** than that of younger owners. Thus, 27.2% of owners 65 and older -- or **1,250** – were calculated to be spending more than 30% of their household incomes on housing, while 23.1% of senior owners, or **1,062**, were calculated to be paying more than 35% of their household incomes for housing – all before later tax or other cost increases or the potentially significant costs of maintenance.⁹

⁷<https://dls-gw.dor.state.ma.us/reports/rdPage.aspx?rdReport=Dashboard.TrendAnalysisReports.TaxLevyByClass>

⁸ FY2027-FY2031 Long Range Financial Forecast, December 9, 2025.

⁹ American Community Survey, 2024 5-year estimates, Table B25093. The total number of owner households paying more than 30% of household income for housing was calculated at 3,352 out of 12,793 computed, or 26.2%. The total number paying more than 35% of household income was 2,778, or 21.7%. The total for owner householders age 65 and over calculated to be paying more than 30% of household income was 1,250 out of 4,598 computed, or 27.2%, with 1,062 or 23.1%, paying more than 35% of household income for housing costs. <https://data.census.gov/table?q=brookline,+ma+B25093>



Renters. Renters are not immune from property tax increases. The standard Greater Boston Realty Board lease includes a tax escalator clause under which increases in property taxes can be immediately passed on to renters:

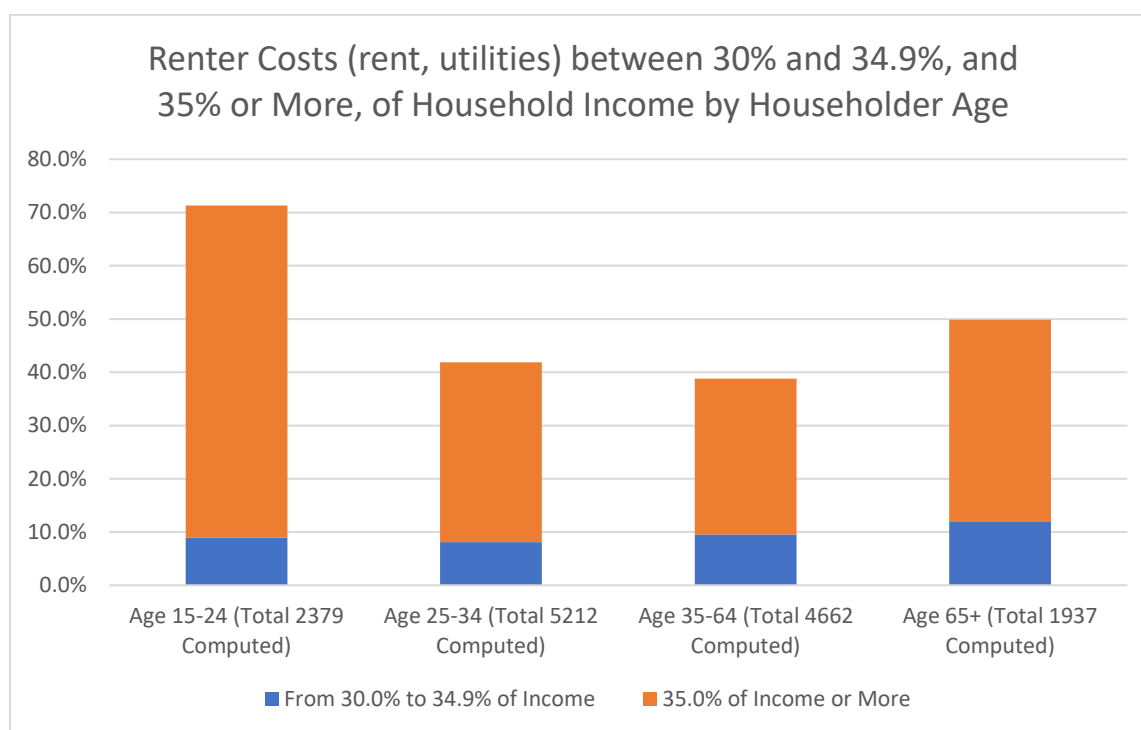
[I]f in any tax year commencing with the fiscal year [] the real estate taxes on the land and buildings, of which the leased premises are a part, are in excess of the amount of the real estate taxes thereon for the ... “Base Year”... Lessee will pay to Lessor as additional rent hereunder, when and as designated by notice in writing by Lessor, ... that proportion of such increased tax as the unit leased him bears to the whole of the real estate so taxed

As discussed above, this “property tax pass-through” would likely have a particularly significant impact on renters in two-family and three-family buildings, where tax increases are borne by fewer units.

The ACS 2024 estimates show an even more profound cost burden for Brookline renters than for owners, across all age groups and particularly among seniors.¹⁰ Among all renting

¹⁰ American Community Survey, 2024 5-year estimates, Table B25072. The total number of renter households paying more than 30% of household income for housing was calculated at 6,653 out of 14,190 computed, or 46.9%. The total number paying more than 35% of household income was 5,341, or 37.6%. Renter housing costs were

households, almost 47%, or **over 6,650** out of 14,190 renting households for which estimates were computed, paid more than 30% of their household income in rent and utilities. Moreover, **over 5,300** renting households, or 37.6%, paid more than 35% of their incomes for housing costs.



Although the impact of housing costs on the youngest age cohort might be trivialized as being just “young people” or “college and graduate school students,” that argument is not relevant for older age groups. All the remaining renter age groups – **and especially the most senior** – were cost-burdened.

Thus, approximately 40% of renters in the 25 to 34 and the 35 to 64 age categories are paying more than 30% of their income in rent and utilities. That is **almost 4,000 renters** out of the 9,874 households of those ages for which estimates were computed. And of those 9,874 households, **over 3,100** (31.6%) paid more than 35% of their household incomes in rent and utilities.

calculated for a total of 9,874 householders in the 25 to 34 and 35 to 64 age cohorts, with 3,991 (40.4%) calculated to be paying more than 30%, and 3,122 (31.6%) to be paying more than 35%, of household income for housing. For renters age 65 and over, 966 out of 1,937 (49.9%) were paying more than 30% of household income for housing while 736 (38%) were paying more than 35% of their household incomes for housing.
<https://data.census.gov/table?q=brookline,+ma+B25072>.

The burdens are even more dramatic for renters over the age of 65. **Virtually half of senior renters (49.9%), almost 1,000 senior renters** out of 1,937 computed, were paying more than 30% of their incomes on rent and utilities, with 38%, or **736 senior renters**, paying more than 35% of their incomes for housing.

7. There should be full disclosure of the total impact of all factors that will increase property taxes, as well as careful scrutiny of ways to reduce the override level.

The cost burdens borne by Brookline residents are based on the 2024 ACS survey, and do not reflect later, or projected, tax increases. For example, the residential levy increased by \$17.6 million, or 6.7%, from FY25 to FY26, and the Town has projected a further 5.1% property tax increase from current FY26 to FY27 and an 11.8% increase by FY29 before the impact of an override. And with the proposed override, **property taxes would rise by 8.3% from current levels in one year and by 19.3% in three years**, immediately after the 6.7% property tax increase that occurred in the current year.

Ultimately, the **total** property tax impact of any override vote should be made clear to voters, including the impact from year to year and the total impact over three years. This would not simply be the isolated impact of the override, but would also include the impact of factors such as embedded Proposition 2 ½ increases and debt exclusions, the compounding of override amounts, and the additional impact of the Community Preservation Act. All such items would impact the property taxes that households would actually be required to pay.¹¹

8. The Select Board can incorporate steps to reduce the size and impact of any override.

The actual necessity of the proposed override amount should also be carefully scrutinized and steps taken to reduce the amount:

- Rather than “front-end loading” the full Town override and Schools’ capture of \$1.9 million of Circuit Breaker funds, consider spreading such amounts over a three-year period to reduce the FY27 “hit” of 8.3%.
- The 83% employer contribution rate for health insurance regardless of the type (HMO, PPO, POS) or cost of the plan, is unsustainable when coupled with the 10% to 12% GIC

¹¹ Consideration could also be given to a one-year override, to allow the current PSB administration to adopt meaningful cost reductions. In the event of a three-year override, consideration could also be given to spreading increases that are now proposed to be front-loaded in FY27 over a three-year period to reduce the FY27 impact.

premium increases over which Brookline has no control. While the contribution rate would have to be collectively bargained, contribution levels in line with comparable communities could, as noted in the “Medical Insurance Premiums” Report of the Schools Subcommittee, save from \$3.5 million to \$7.9 million per year over the period of the proposed override. The override should not be based on simply accepting the 83% contribution rate as a “given” that will persist for three more years. In setting the override level, the Select Board should consider incorporating the savings that would result from a more reasonable employer contribution rate, with the application of those savings timed to allow a period of a 9 months to 15 months for collective bargaining. Utilizing even the most conservative \$3.5 million figure would have a significant impact on the override amount.

- Similarly, the impact of “steps” on salaries is unsustainable over time, as set forth in “School Salaries: The Impact of ‘Steps’ on Actual Salaries & PSB Salaries in Comparison to Similar Districts,” as reported by the Schools Subcommittee. While salaries should be competitive, Brookline School salaries exceed the median levels in districts identified as similar by PSB.

In particular, “steps” increase actual salaries for PSB employees and for some Town employees at a rate well in excess of inflation and nominal cost-of-living increases, indeed up to 8% annually. Even though only 52% of PSB educators remain on the “steps and lanes” grid, salary increases for PSB employees were forecast at 5% per year by Dr. Susan Givens at the 2/26/26 School Committee meeting – with no increase in FTEs. That 5% figure is in addition to the effective additional 1.8% increase that results from increasing health benefit costs, an unsustainable 6.8% annual increase.¹²

A reduction of the overall 5% increase in \$125 million in PSB wages to a more sustainable overall increase of 2.5% or even 3% would result in savings of \$2.5 million to \$3 million per year over the period of the override (in addition to savings on the Town side). The effective increase in aggregate employee compensation, including health benefits, would still be well over the expected growth in revenues, but would at least be somewhat mitigated. This issue must also be collectively bargained, but salaries must be at a level that is sustainable over time without the expectation of continuing overrides. The override should not accept unsustainable salary increases as a “given,” and the Select Board should therefore consider incorporating these savings in the override level after a period for collective bargaining.

- PSB should enforce provisions of the contract regarding teaching loads at the High School, and the Select Board should be prepared to set an override level that incorporates the resulting savings.

¹²The average Brookline teacher salary in 2023-24 – three years prior to the first override year – was \$122,389. <https://profiles.doe.mass.edu/statereport/teachersalaries.aspx> Brookline’s current 83% contribution for 1789 active Town and School employees is \$32,804,684 (see Table 1, “Medical Insurance Premiums” Report of the Schools Subcommittee), or an average of \$18,337 per employee. Health insurance premiums are projected to increase by 12% per year, or \$2,200 per employee, or approximately 1.8% of the average 2023-2024 salary.

The current collective bargaining agreement provides: “Grades 9-12 teachers shall have a maximum of twenty (20) assigned instructional periods and four (4) periods of other assigned duties (one of which may be a homeroom), except as the BSC [Brookline School Committee] has previously voted otherwise.” There is also a “goal” of an aggregate student load of 115 students, with the Head of School required to “make efforts” to reduce the load to 115.

For High School teachers teaching courses that meet only four times per week, this would allow the assignment of five courses plus four other duties. This apparently applies in English, Math, Social Studies, World Languages, and some Science courses (with some Science courses meeting 5 times per week with labs). Only 11 out of 94 teachers now have teaching loads of more than 100 students, and the current average teaching loads in all five discipline range from 82.4 to 92.7, indicating opportunities to increase per-teacher instructional periods from 4 to 5 without exceeding the goal of 115.

In fact, at the 2/26/26 School Committee meeting, PSB identified the potential to save 8 FTEs by shifting some “4+1” assignments to teaching 5 courses (1.4 FTEs) in FY27 regardless of the outcome of an override, and by rotating a portion of “4+1” assignments if an override fails (an additional 6.6 FTEs). The 6.6 FTEs could reduce the required override by approximately \$900,000 annually, or a total of more than \$2.7 million over three years,¹³ and should be incorporated as a minimum in setting the override level.¹⁴

- Accordingly, the unsustainable status quo should not be accepted as a “given” that will burden Town and School finances for the next three years, if not beyond. The Select Board could put a single override on the ballot that incorporates all of the savings described above. The Select Board could also offer a “tiered” override. Both tiers could “phase in” Town and School amounts over three years, rather than front-end loading certain amounts, and also incorporate modifications to the “4+1” system already identified by PSB (a reduction of 6.6 FTEs, or approximately \$900,000 per year when benefits are included).

Both override tiers would preserve Town and School services, rather than finding savings by eliminating fire companies and middle school World Languages. The lower tier would

¹³ The average Brookline teacher salary in 2023-24 – three years prior to the first override year – was \$122,389. <https://profiles.doe.mass.edu/statereport/teachersalaries.aspx> Brookline’s current 83% contribution for 1789 active Town and School employees is \$32,804,684 (see Table 1, “Medical Insurance Premiums” Report of the Schools Subcommittee), or an average of \$18,337 per employee, resulting a total of over \$140,000 per employee for just wages plus health insurance, or approximately \$900,000 annually for 6.6 FTE positions.

PSB should prepare to implement all potential staff reductions by complying with the notice requirements of the collective bargaining agreement regarding layoffs to the levels required if an override were to fail.

¹⁴ Even greater savings might be possible than those already identified by PSB. It has been argued that Tutorials are “instructional periods” and not “other assigned duties.” Overseeing a Tutorial of 10 students with two teachers is of course not equivalent in terms of preparation and grading to teaching an academic course with, for example, 23 students. The application of the “instructional period” and “other assigned duties” terminology would have to be resolved, along with the assignment of teachers to academic courses and the structure of duties other than academic courses to determine the potential for additional savings.

expressly incorporate an employer health insurance contribution rate in line with most similar school communities (saving at least \$3.5 million, and up to \$7.9 million, per year). The lower tier would also incorporate a 2.5% or 3% annual increase in Town and School wages (saving between \$2.5 and \$3 million per year of School wages, plus a further amount in Town wages). The higher override tier would offer voters the choice of continuing to fund the 83% employer contribution rate for health insurance premiums and the existing increases in School salaries of approximately 5% per year as well as Town salary increases, in addition to increases in benefit costs of 12% per year.

- The override calculations should also incorporate revenue and savings identified by E&RSC subcommittees, including:
 - Capturing savings projected during the override period from the Solar Initiative recommended by the Futures Subcommittee.
 - At a minimum, ensuring that the Brookline Early Education Program (BEEP) tuition is covering the costs of the program, particularly an apparent shortfall in the Extended Day portion of the program, as set forth in the “Cost Savings and Revenue Opportunities through the Brookline Early Education Program” Report of the Schools Subcommittee.
- Finally, there should be a commitment to recommendations of E&RSC subcommittees, including:
 - In addition to the foregoing, a deep review of the of the tuition being charged for both full and extended day BEEP programs, as there are programs that are offered for less than market rates, as well as programs being offered for less than the cost of the program.
 - A robust analysis of the Special Education costs attributable to non-resident students and pursuit of additional funding from the State for the Special Education costs attributable to METCO students. This could be done in cooperation with other communities, including Newton and Lexington, who together with Brookline receive the largest number of METCO students in eastern Massachusetts.
 - Evaluation of the financial and educational benefits and costs of conversion to a middle school model.
 - A pilot program to manage rentals and use of public buildings and facilities, including use by third parties, Town and School departments and affiliated not-for-profit organizations.
 - Potential consolidation of functions serving both the Town and Schools.
 - Evaluation and possible amendment the Town/School financial model, including the methodology used to assign or “split” revenues, the allocation of costs “above the line” or “below the line,” and the creation of clear working relationships for Town departments and for the Schools regarding the assignment of responsibility, funding and control of costs and services.
 - Independent review of the steps taken with regard to the Clifton Larson Allen report on PSB administration.

The size of the override and the capacity of households to pay any override are critical issues.

The Town would not be well served by the imposition of onerous burdens on residents – owners or renters; young, middle-age or senior -- or, conversely, by the failure of an override that voters find unacceptable.

DRAFT